

Herrera

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that I went to a school where the kids had plenty to eat. It was really different. But I had some good kids and enjoyed the time I spent there."

The year he retired, 1970, was the last time the Thunderbird squad has reached the baseball playoffs.

"I never quit working," Herrera said. "I was 70 when I left El Paso and enjoyed every minute out there."

Herrera coached for 43 years, longer than any other high school coach in Texas. His career records: 15 wins and 193 losses in basketball, 15 wins against 355 losses in baseball.

One player Herrera is proud of is Nolan Richardson, who played and later coached at Bowie. Richardson is now head basketball coach at the University of Tulsa.

"He was one of the best athletes that I ever had the pleasure of coaching," Herrera recalls. "That kid could do everything. He was a full letterman. I remember one time during the spring, I had him in baseball and after practice, there was a track meet going on. He asked me if he could go in a medal and I told him he wasn't in shape. But he wanted to try so I let him and, sure enough, he came back with a blue ribbon for high jumping feet."

And Richardson is one of those kids who still keeps in touch with Herrera. "I plan on seeing him in July," Richardson said. "I played for him longer than any other coach; heck, I played baseball for him for nine years. He is one of the finest coaches I've ever been around."

"He was tough and he made us work," Richardson added. "We used to call him *el chongo* (the monkey) and he wanted me to become a baseball coach. I remember he was the

first coach to ever go to my house and talk to my grandmother. Since I didn't have a father, he kept an eye on me. I don't think there are many guys who played for him that didn't love him."

Another experience still vivid in Herrera's memory is the discrimination against his teams in the '40s.

"They didn't care too much for Mexicans or blacks out in West Texas," Herrera said. "I remember one time we went to Abilene and were in a restaurant eating when the owner came up and asked us what we were doing there. He told us to leave and that made me mad as hell. I told my boys not to worry about it. We went there to play and that was all."

"They were all good kids. I wouldn't allow long hair, back talk or smart alecks. I had hundreds of kids. I disciplined them by using a board and I'd pop 'em on the butt."

What does Herrera do now?

"Well, as soon as I retired, some friends of mine told me about a job at Kelly Air Force Base back in San Antonio," Herrera said. "So, in September of 1970, I was working as a recreation director."

Herrera's accomplishments have not gone unnoticed. He is in the El Paso and San Antonio halls of fame and Texas High School Coaches Hall of Honor.

"The '49 baseball team was honored at Bowie's homecoming last year and some of my boys even set up a Nemo Herrera scholarship fund to help Mexican-American kids. We have an all-star baseball game every summer for the top boys and girls in San Antonio to raise money and that's pretty successful."

"It makes me feel really good when my kids do things like that for me. I would have to say that my tenure has been a very enjoyable one."